articulation, it was the officials who by carrying out their duties would enable Ashoka to discharge this debt. A sense of solidarity between ruler and administration was being sought, and one imagines that this message was necessitated by problems specific to Kalinga.

In most places, Ashoka's engraved messages were read out by officials. This, in turn, entailed careful listening by the people gathered. For his 'unconquered borderers' and in Kalinga, the king practically ordered that these edicts be regularly read out. Separate Rock Edict 1 is pretty straightforward in telling his officials to get the job done: 'And this edict must be listened to (by all) on (every day of) the constellation Tishya. And it may be listened to even by a single (person) also on frequent (other) occasions between (the days of) Tishya. And if you act thus, you will be able to fulfil (this duty).'[50] Considering that the edict is primarily concerned with improving administration and justice delivery, a reading between the lines seems called for: the emperor seems to be saying he disapproves of the existing state of affairs and has given officials specific redressal instructions. Via repeated broadcasts heard at least three times a year (implied by reference to the Tishya constellation), some sort of accountability is being attempted. The line ensuing makes this apparent: 'in order that the judicial officers of the city may strive at all times (for this), (that) neither undeserved fettering nor undeserved harsh treatment are happening to (men).'[51]

He says, further, and specifically at this location, that a quinquennial scrutiny will be conducted by a mahamatra of suitable character, 'neither harsh nor fierce, [but] of gentle actions',[52] to ascertain if judicial officers have been acting according to instructions. This promise of supervision was not restricted to Kalinga: other centres of provincial administration—Ujjayini and Takshashila are specifically named—were also instructed to send out mahamatras for the same purpose triennially. On account of this command it has been assumed that these separate edicts were not Kalinga-